

MANEESH AGNIHOTRI





BAHUBALI COMPLEX (Clockwise from above) File pix of Amarmani Tripathi, (inset) son Amanmani; Mukhtar (left) and Afzal Ansari

accompanied by other senior party leaders on January 4.

But even here, a cross-connection could complicate matters. The Ansari brothers gained the most notoriety for the 2005 murder of BJP legislator Krishnanand Rai in Ghazipur, in which they are the prime accused. In 2019, a special CBI court in Delhi acquitted the Ansaris and five others, but an appeal is pending in the Delhi High Court. Krishnanand's brother Ajay Rai is currently the state unit chief of the Congress, and the SP and Congress have an alliance for the coming Lok Sabha polls. Mukhtar, a former MLA from Mau, has 52 cases filed against him, 15 of which are at the trial stage. His son, Abbas Ansari, is currently the Mau MLA. Both father and son are currently in jail, Abbas on a money-laundering charge.

State BJP spokesperson Rakesh Tripathi alleges the Opposition has hit its nadir, which is why it is shielding "mafia and criminal elements". "The Congress has inducted a member of a criminal family who is accused of killing his wife, while the SP chief is attending the wedding of the Ansaris and disbursing tickets. What does this show?" The Opposition, in turn, points to Brij Bhushan Sharan Singh, the disgraced ex-Wrestling Federation of India president, Kaiserganj MP and strongman, who, too, faced a number of such charges at one point. The blame game aside, it pays to have a *bahubali* or two on your team when election is round the corner. ■

NEW DUO TAKE ON BIG TWO

J&K Apni Party and DPAP along with People's Conference hope to end the old dominance of the National Conference and the PDP in the Lok Sabha polls

By Moazum Mohammad *in Srinagar*

Jammu and Kashmir is getting ready for its first Lok Sabha election since the abrogation of Article 370 and the bifurcation of the erstwhile state into Union territories. Making the contest interesting is the presence of two new local parties—the J&K Apni Party and Democratic Progressive Azad Party (DPAP), both of which cropped up after 2019. Along with the J&K People's Conference, they are posing an unforeseen challenge to the traditional dominance of the National Conference (NC) and Peoples Democratic Party (PDP). Polls are to be held in the UT in the first five of the seven phases: April 19 (Udhampur constituency), April 26 (Jammu), May 7 (Anantnag-Rajouri), May 13 (Srinagar) and May 20 (Baramulla). The erstwhile J&K state had six Lok Sabha seats—three in Kashmir, two in Jammu, one in Ladakh. After its bifurcation under the Jammu and Kashmir Reorganisation Act 2019 increased the number of assembly constituencies to 114 from 107, a delimitation exercise became necessary. Post that exercise, LS seats in J&K remain at five, but electoral boundaries have been redrawn, allegedly altering the political landscape in favour of the BJP.

The J&K Apni Party came up in March 2020. Led by the former PDP leader Syed Altaf Bukhari, it is a collective of former